

SCAFFOLD

SUPPORTS TERTIARY WHY

FOR WHAT-HOW · HOW-WHAT

The Five-Question Purpose Brief

A ten-minute structured brief, completed once before any significant piece of work begins. **It generates the purpose thinking that would otherwise cost you real energy**, and captures it in a form you can reference for the life of the project instead of regenerating it every time someone asks.

THE DRAIN

When your energy lives in progress and precision, articulating purpose is draining work. The instinct is to skip it and start executing, and that instinct has a cost: rework, effort that quietly drifts from the goal, and finished deliverables that answer the wrong question. Purpose questions also tend to arrive mid-project, from stakeholders, at the worst possible time to answer them.

WHAT THIS TOOL DOES

The brief contains the purpose work inside ten structured minutes at the start, when it is cheapest. Five questions produce the essential thinking a WHY-primary generates naturally: who the work serves, what it changes, and why it matters now. Answered once and posted where the work lives, the brief becomes the reference point for every scope decision, status update, and stakeholder conversation that follows.

The five questions

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|--------------------------------|--|
| 1 Who is this for? | Name the actual person or group, not the org chart. |
| 2 What changes if it succeeds? | Describe the after-state in one sentence. |
| 3 Why now? | What makes this the right moment, and what is it competing with? |
| 4 What does success mean? | How everyone will know, without debate, that it worked. |
| 5 What if we do nothing? | The honest cost of not doing this work. |

HOW TO USE IT

- 1 Block ten minutes before any planning starts.** If the work has a requester, answer the questions with them in the room. Their answers are the brief.
- 2 Write plain sentences, not fragments.** One or two sentences per question. If an answer will not come, that is a signal the work is not ready to start.
- 3 Post it where the work lives.** Top of the project doc, first slide of the deck, pinned in the channel. Refer to it, never regenerate it.
- 4 Revisit only when scope changes.** The brief is stable by design. If the answers change, the project changed, and everyone should know.

WHAT IT WON'T DO

This tool will not make purpose work energizing, and it is not meant to. It reduces the cost of tertiary WHY work by containing it: ten structured minutes instead of a recurring drain across the life of the project. For high-stakes or ambiguous work, pair the brief with a review from a WHY-primary colleague, the right partner completes the picture rather than compensating for a gap.

IN THE KIT

Fillable worksheet (print + digital)

Facilitator prompts

Example completed brief

PAIRS WELL WITH

Tool 22 North Star One-Pager · **Tool 24** The So-What Translator · **Tool 29** The Opening Line Habit